

115 Nehemiah

The king's cupbearer who prayed, planned and rebuilt Jerusalem's walls in fifty-two days.

Nehemiah was cupbearer to the Persian king Artaxerxes I. Hearing that Jerusalem's walls lay in ruins, he wept and prayed. Then, with a quick silent prayer, he asked the king to send him to rebuild the city. As governor he rallied the people, and despite enemies the wall was finished in fifty-two days. He also defended the poor and later cleansed the temple. His memoir is full of short prayers: "Remember me, O my God, for good."

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Nechemyah</i> , "the Lord comforts"
Family	Son of Hachaliah; brother of Hanani (Nehemiah 1:1-2; 7:2)
Role	Cupbearer to Artaxerxes I, then governor (Neh 1:11; 5:14)
When	Came c. 445/444 BC; governor twelve years, to c. 433/432 BC
Enemies	Sanballat, Tobiah the Ammonite, Geshem (Nehemiah 2:19)
Key people	Hanani, Ezra, Eliashib the high priest
Main passages	Nehemiah 1-13
New Testament	Not named

"Then answered I them, and said unto them, The God of heaven, he will prosper us; therefore we his servants will arise and build: but ye have no portion, nor right, nor memorial, in Jerusalem."

Nehemiah 2:20, KJV

The life of Nehemiah

Dates approximate (BC), counted from Artaxerxes I (465–424 BC); scholars differ by a year.

- c. 446/445 BC

20th year,
Chisleu

●

Bad news from Jerusalem

In Shushan, Nehemiah hears that Jerusalem's wall is broken down. He weeps, fasts and prays. *Nehemiah 1:1–11*
- c. 445 BC

20th year,
Nisan

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The king's question

When the king asks why he is sad, he prays silently, then asks to be sent to rebuild. *Nehemiah 2:1–8*
- c. 445/444 BC

On arrival

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A night inspection

He views the ruined walls by night, and the leaders answer, "Let us rise up and build." *Nehemiah 2:11–20*
- c. 445/444 BC

During the
building

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Trowel, sword and justice

He arms the builders against attack and makes the nobles return what they took from the poor. *Nehemiah 4:1–23; 5:1–13*
- c. 445/444 BC

25th of Elul

●

The wall finished

Despite traps and threats, the wall is completed in fifty-two days, "wrought of our God." *Nehemiah 6:1–16*
- c. 433/432 BC
and later

●

Second term and reforms

Returning to Jerusalem, he throws out Tobiah's goods, guards the Sabbath and confronts mixed marriages. *Nehemiah 13:4–31*

Group notes

Key activities

Nehemiah could be fierce. When he found Jews married to foreign wives, he "contended with them, and cursed them, and smote certain of them, and plucked off their hair" (Nehemiah 13:25). Some readers admire his zeal for God. Others see a leader whose methods went too far. The text records it without comment.

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- I Wept and prayed first.** He mourned for days and confessed the sins of Israel, including his own family's. *Nehemiah 1:4-11*

 - 2 Prayed on the spot.** When the king asked what he wanted, he sent up a silent prayer before he answered. *Nehemiah 2:4-5*

 - 3 Planned ahead.** He asked for letters of safe passage and for timber for the gates, the wall and his house. *Nehemiah 2:7-8*

 - 4 Looked before he spoke.** He inspected the walls by night and told no one his plan until he knew the facts. *Nehemiah 2:12-16*

 - 5 Rallied the people.** He shared how God's hand had been on him, and they said, "Let us rise up and build." *Nehemiah 2:17-18*

 - 6 Organised the work.** Families, priests and even goldsmiths each built a section, many near their own homes. *Nehemiah 3:1-32*

 - 7 Prayed and posted guards.** "We made our prayer unto our God, and set a watch against them day and night." *Nehemiah 4:9*

 - 8 Armed the builders.** Each worked with one hand and held a weapon with the other. *Nehemiah 4:13-18*

 - 9 Stopped injustice.** He forced the nobles to stop charging their own people interest and to return their land. *Nehemiah 5:1-13*

 - 10 Refused his allowance.** For twelve years he did not take the governor's food allowance, "because of the fear of God." *Nehemiah 5:14-19*

 - II Would not be distracted.** He answered his enemies, "I am doing a great work, so that I cannot come down." *Nehemiah 6:1-14*

 - 12 Dedicated the wall with joy.** Two great choirs walked the walls, and "the joy of Jerusalem was heard even afar off." *Nehemiah 12:27-43*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Nehemiah.
Tradition: 2 Maccabees 2:13 (Apocrypha) says he founded a library of sacred books.

Old Testament

Nehemiah 1-13	His own memoir, mostly in the first person
Nehemiah 8:9; 10:1; 12:26, 47	Named governor ("Tirshatha") alongside Ezra
Ezra 2:2; Nehemiah 3:16	Two other men named Nehemiah
Echo: Psalm 127:1	"Except the LORD build the house ..."

New Testament

Echo: John 2:13-16	Jesus clears the temple, as Nehemiah threw out Tobiah's goods
Echo: Luke 14:28	Counting the cost before building

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Nehemiah do in the moment between the king's question and his answer (Nehemiah 2:4-5)?
2. *Understand:* Nehemiah both prayed and set a guard (Nehemiah 4:9). How do trusting God and taking practical action fit together?
3. *Apply:* Nehemiah was moved by news of broken walls far away. What need is God stirring your heart about, and what first step could you take?
4. *Apply:* His enemies tried to pull him away from "a great work." What distractions keep you from what God has given you to do, and how can you say no to one this week?